

A

When / As soon as

The meaning of these two time expressions is almost the same, but **as soon as** suggests something more immediate or important.

I'll phone my uncle **when** / **as soon as** I get home.

As soon as / **When** you've finished this exercise, you can go home.

Common mistakes

I'll see you **when** I **get** there. (NOT I'll see you when I ~~will~~ get there.)

We don't use a future form after *when* / *as soon as*.

B

Two things happening at the same time

Violet got ready **while** I cooked the dinner. [two long actions]

The accident happened **while** I was on my way to work. [a longer action 'on my way to work' and a short action 'the accident'; we can also use **when** or **as** here.]

I saw him (**just**) **as** I came out of the office. [two short actions happening at the same time; we can also use **when** here]

C

One thing after another

We met the others in the café, and **then** / **after that** / **afterwards** we went to the match.

I talked to Joe, and **afterwards** [at a later time but usually the same day] I came home.

I was in Caracas for three months, and **then** / **after that** I went to Colombia.

After my visit to New York, I decided to have a rest.

We had something to eat **before** going out.

Common mistakes

After **seeing** the film, we went home.
(NOT After see the film, we went home.)

D

A sequence* of actions

We had a really nice holiday. **First of all** / **First** we spent a few days in St Moritz. **After that** / **Then** we drove down the coast and stayed in Portofino for a week. **Finally**, we went back to Switzerland to stay with my uncle. (*Finally* is used here to introduce the last thing in a list.)

* one action after another, and so on

E

At first ... eventually

To begin with, the two girls got on very well when they shared the flat. But after **a while** [a period of time], they started arguing about various things, and **eventually** [finally, after a long time or a lot of problems] Lauren walked out and found a new place.

At first I enjoyed the classes, but after a while it got a bit boring, and **in the end** [finally, after a period of time or thought] I left.

F

A list of reasons

We can use **firstly** / **for one thing** / **for a start** to introduce a first reason for something, and then **secondly**/ **besides**/ **anyway** to add a further reason.

A: What's wrong with her new dress?

B: **Firstly**, it's a horrible colour, and **secondly**, I don't think it suits her.

A: Why can't we go out tonight?

B: Well, **for one thing** / **for a start**, I've got a lot of work – and **besides/anyway**, I can't afford it.